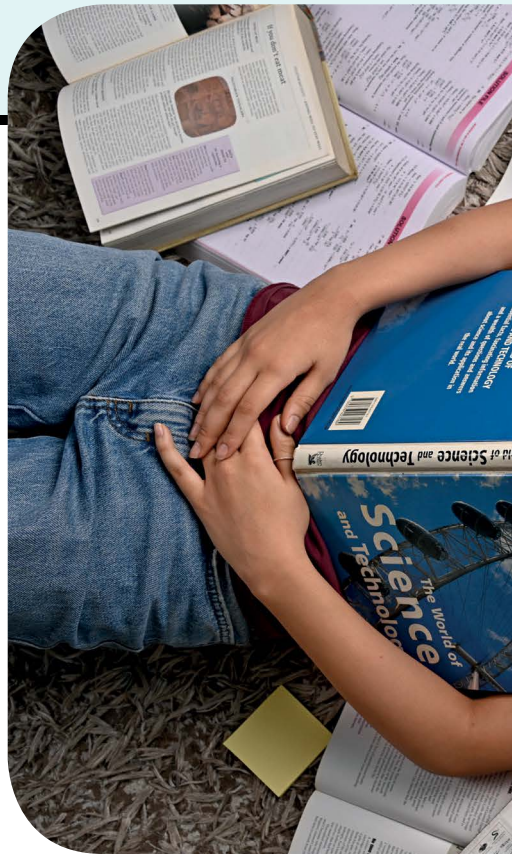
says, "Parents feel that with the growing mobility in the job market, a multicultural university experience equips their children better for success."

Never Mind the Money

For many Indian parents, money is not a consideration to begin with. Better financial planning and more disposable incomes make it possible for them to invest more in their children's education. Education loans, especially without collaterals, have made the process smoother and a lot more accessible for students in recent years. "Collateral-free loans, which work on predicting students' eventual outcome, have been a key factor in the increasing demand for studies abroad," says Buch.

For Prodigy Finance, an international student lender, India has been one of the fastest growing markets, with the company seeing a 72 per cent rise in applications from India in 2022 and a 73 per cent increase in loan disbursements for Indian students. "The average loan size in the year is Rs 31 lakh for us," says Mayank Sharma, head, global partnerships, and country head, India. The trend is visible even in India's small towns. For instance, Avanse Financial Services, a non-banking financial company focused on education, reported a significant demand for student loans from Tier II and III cities in FY23.

Another significant factor is the range of study abroad platforms. From determining student aptitude, identifying the courses best suited to them to helping them write applications, tests, extra-curricular activities as well as the all-important statement of purpose (SOP) essay, these forums hand-hold students through the entire journey from home to university. Of course, the guidance comes at a fee, and that fee is not cheap. Yocket, for instance, helps students with end-to-end counselling under 'Yocket Premium' that includes test preparation, country and course selection, university shortlisting, documentation such as a resume, SOP and letter of recommendation, university applications, educational loan guidance and visas. Each student gets a dedicated counsellor along with a bunch of other experts. The fee varies from Rs 90,000 to Rs 1.3 lakh for bachelor's and from Rs 27,000 to Rs 90,000 for master's, depending on the profile of the student and the services taken. They also have a free platform for students to do research. Athena Education, on the other hand, helps students with bespoke mentorship in terms of career and educational counselling, psychometric assessment, curating a customised list of universities for the right fit, support with application and documentation and post-admission services. The average fee per student is Rs 5 lakh per year.



RAJWANT RAWAT



"THE GRADUATE IMMIGRATION ROUTE THAT ALLOWS STUDENTS TO UNDERTAKE POST-STUDY WORK IN THE UK IS A KEY FACTOR IN THE APPEAL OF OUR UNIVERSITIES TO INDIA"

– PROF. CHARLIE JEFFERY, Vice-chancellor, University of York, UK

Students can also refer to the QS World University Rankings, Times Higher Education World University Rankings and country-specific rankings such as US News for the US. Education USA India and British Council India-Study UK are other useful resources that guide students through the whole process of academic and visa applications.

Universities abroad are also keen on attracting international students, because the fees they pay cross-subsidises local students. Of course, there are benefits to the host nation's economy as well as these students hire accommodation or eat out at restaurants. Between 2018-19 and 2021-22, international students contributed £41.9 billion (Rs 4.4 lakh crore) to the UK economy.

Foreign universities also welcome international students because of the cultural diversity they bring to their classrooms. As David C. Malloy, president, King's University College, Ontario, Canada, says, "At King's, we have created a global microcosm, with our Canadian students gaining an international experience by welcoming more than 800 students from 40 countries to share their cultural and intellectual outlooks. We also put very specific orientations in place for our international students to welcome them to King's and to Canada."